with Bhagat Singh, one of Punjab's greatest martyrs—his passion project, one that stayed with him even as he became Mumbai's leading casting director on films like *Omkara*, *Fukrey*, *Udta Punjab* and *Hindi Medium*. He found the collaborators he wanted in producer Ronnie Screwvala (*Rang De Basanti*, *Uri: The Surgical Strike*) and actor-singer Diljit Dosanjh. Shot across 137 locations in Punjab between February and May 2022, in the immediate aftermath of the COVID-19 pandemic, the film was Trehan's attempt to tell a story that "makes sense to Punjab". "It is high time for Punjab to have some serious cinema that can open a dialogue," he says.

While Trehan uses creative licence to keep his protagonist apolitical on screen, Khalra's daughter, Navkiran Kaur Khalra, now based in the US, is not shy about her father's politics. She speaks of employing "every means of resistance" against the Indian State, and says the film is one way of showing that "the system does not listen to us". Her father, she promises, will continue to "haunt" India. Khalra's widow, Paramjit Kaur, contested the 2019 Lok Sabha election on a Punjab Ekta Party ticket, backed by hardliners, but lost.

Omissions and Commissions

Originally titled *Punjab '95*, Trehan and producer Screwvala spent three years fighting the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC), which is why Trehan regards its brief legal availability as a small miracle. Submitted to CBFC in 2023 with an eye on international film festivals, the makers were asked to make 21 cuts, which they refused to accept, taking the matter to the Bombay High Court instead. The standoff dragged on until 2024, by which point CBFC's list of cuts had swelled to an astonishing 127. Trehan said he gave Screwvala the option to release the film with the 127 cuts but not to carry his or Dosanjh's names then. Screwvala stood by him and approached ZEE5—which already had *The Kashmir Files* and *The*

JASWANT SINGH KHALRA
MAN BEHIND THE MARTYR

From student agitator and Sikh nationalist to investigator of Punjab's missing—and, after his custodial murder, the progenitor of a continuing political legacy

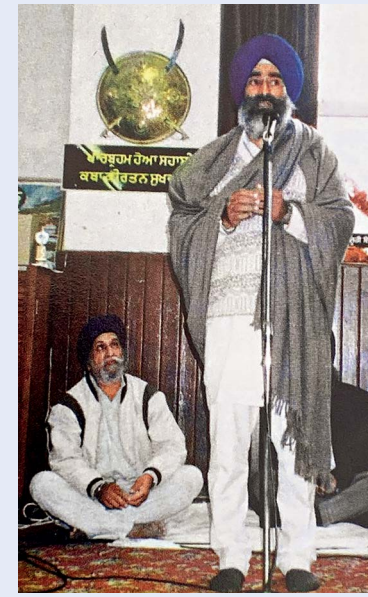
THE BORN ACTIVIST: Born in Khalra village in 1952, Jaswant Singh Sandhu took his village name as his surname, partly as a rejection of caste identities. Joined Naujawan Bharat Sabha in 1973, documented the alleged killings of young men in police encounters in Punjab. Worked at electricity board and later at Amritsar Central Cooperative Bank. Married Paramjit Kaur in 1981

THE POLITICAL CAMPAIGNER: Op. Bluestar drew Khalra into Sikh politics and activism. He was associated with the Akali Dal, guiding civil-liberties fact-finding teams in Punjab

KHALISTAN SYMPATHISER: Moved to the UK in 1990, applied for political asylum and renounced Indian citizenship voluntarily the next year. Formed Liberation Khalistan Movement International and also edited *Liberation Khalistan* magazine. In his writings, praised Bhindranwale as a *qaumi* hero and described the armed campaign as a struggle for Sikh freedom, distinguished Sikh "militant tradition" from terrorism. No evidence of his joining the militancy. Returned to India in 1992 and became general secretary of Akali Dal's human rights wing

COUNTER OF THE MISSING: As the counterinsurgency intensified, Khalra met families of the abducted. The disappearance of colleague Piara Singh brought the issue close to him. Working with Jaspal Singh Dhillon and others, he began trying to establish if the missing had been killed in custody or in purported 'encounters'

HUMAN RIGHTS CHAMP: In late 1994, Khalra and his colleagues examined registers at the Durgiana Mandir, Patti and Tarn Taran cremation grounds, cross-checking them with municipal firewood records. In Jan. 1995, they alleged that, between 1984 and 1994, 2,097 bodies were brought by the police and cremated as unidentified. He publicised findings abroad and extrapolated it to 25,000 clandestine cremations statewide



THE MARTYR: On Sept. 6, 1995, six days after Beant Singh's assassination, Khalra was abducted from his Amritsar home. Evidence later established that police personnel tortured and murdered him and disposed of his body in the Sutlej. The SC ordered a CBI inquiry, police officers were convicted. The NHRC identified 1,513 victims eligible for compensation in the cremations case

THE AFTERMATH: Khalra's legacy remains politically contentious. Wife Paramjit contested the Lok Sabha polls in 1999 on a Sarab Hind Shiromani Akali Dal ticket; in 2019, for the Punjab Ekta Party and lost both times. Their US-based daughter Navkiran Kaur is a vocal defender of her father's political legacy, promising that Khalra will continue to "haunt the system"